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The Contours of Modern India

After centuries of foreign domination, India finally became independent on 15 August 1947. Unfortunately it was not a time of unmitigated celebration. The subcontinent was partitioned at birth into Muslim-dominated Pakistan and Hindu-majority India, which predictably was a very bloody affair. The matter did not end there. Over a third of the country was ruled by local princes who were less than enthusiastic about losing their kingdoms. There were even enclaves still ruled by the French and the Portuguese, leftovers from the age of colonial conquest. Add to this the fact that the long border with China (initially Tibet) was disputed. Thus, the borders of modern India were not established in August 1947, but evolved to their current shape only in the mid-1970s, when Sikkim was incorporated into the Union. The continued disputes with China and Pakistan mean that the contours are still not set in stone. We now turn to the story of how modern India came to have its present borders.

THE PARTITION

Much has been written about the political events that led to the partition of India. Given the geographical focus of this book, I do not wish to recount these events except to say that, at its core, it was the result of a fundamental disagreement about the nature of India’s civilizational nationhood. Indeed, Mohammad Ali Jinnah explicitly stated his demand for Pakistan in civilizational terms on several occasions. It is not a divergence in world